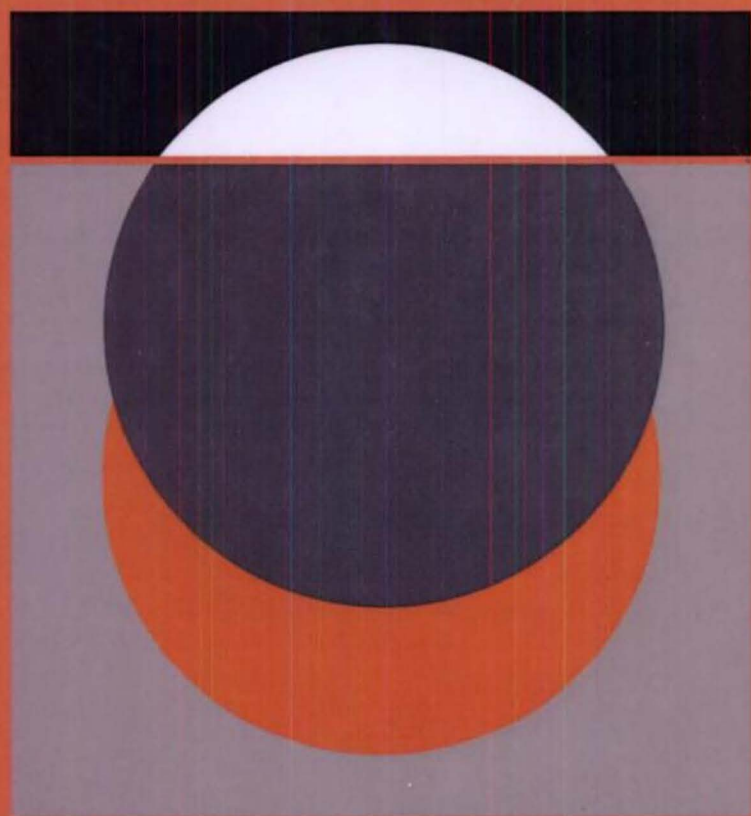


CAMBRIDGE STUDIES IN THE HISTORY OF PSYCHOLOGY

CONSTRUCTING THE SUBJECT



HISTORICAL ORIGINS OF
PSYCHOLOGICAL RESEARCH

KURT DANZIGER

Cambridge Studies in the History of Psychology

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Constructing the subject

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Historical origins of psychological research

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Preface

Historical studies of the sciences tend to adopt one of two rather divergent points of view. One of these typically looks at historical developments in a discipline from the inside. It is apt to take for granted many of the presuppositions that are currently popular among members of the discipline and hence tends to view the past in terms of gradual progress toward a better present. The second point of view does not adopt its framework of issues and presuppositions from the field that is the object of study but tends nowadays to rely heavily on questions and concepts derived from studies in the history, philosophy, and sociology of science. A history written from the insider's point of view always conveys a strong sense of being "our" history. That is not the case with the second type of history, whose tone is apt to be less celebratory and more critical.

In the case of the older sciences, histories of the second type have for many years been the province of specialists in the history, philosophy, or sociology of science. This is not, or perhaps not yet, the case for psychology, whose history has to a large extent been left to psychologists to pursue. Accordingly, insiders' histories have continued to have a prominence they have long lost in the older sciences. Nevertheless, much recent work in the history of psychology has broken with this tradition. Although my own formal training was in psychology, I have tried, in the present volume, to adopt a broader perspective and to analyze the history of this discipline within a framework that owes much to the field of science studies. Inevitably, the result is not what it would have been had my own disciplinary affiliation been outside psychology. Perhaps I have produced a different kind of insider's history. That is for the reader to judge.

This book is not, however, a history of modern psychology. First of all, I have limited myself to certain aspects of that history, albeit aspects that I consider to be fundamental. In the first chapter I explain my reasons for

my choice of topics. The general framework I have adopted is of course applicable to other topics beyond those analyzed here.

The time period covered by the present study is also limited. Because the focus is on historical *origins* of psychological research, developments beyond the first four decades of the twentieth century are not considered. This work is concerned with the formative period of modern psychology, and the beginning of World War II is taken as a rough marker of the end of that period. This does not exclude brief references to later developments, nor does it include some developments at the end of this period whose major impact did not occur until somewhat later.

Finally, practical considerations made it impossible to extend the analysis presented here to many important fields whose early development was peripheral to the major thrust of the discipline. For example, when I first planned this book I had intended to include some discussion of psychoanalysis. However, I soon realized that it would require a different major study to do justice to that topic. Somewhat similar considerations apply to other potentially interesting areas like developmental and social psychology.

I am indebted to my graduate students, Adrian Brock, John Dunbar, Cindi Goodfield, James Parker, Nancy Schmidt, Peter Shermer, and Richard Walsh, some of whom did much of the content analysis of psychological journals that I have used in various parts of this book and all of whom helped me to clarify my ideas in countless discussions. James Parker and Peter Shermer made specific contributions of their own that strongly influenced my treatment of some of the topics in chapters 5, 9, and 10.

I would also like to express my thanks to Mitchell Ash, Gerald Cupchik, Gerd Gigerenzer, Rolf Kroger, Ian Lubek, Jill Morawski, David Rennie, Irmgard Staeuble, Piet van Strien, Malcolm Westcott, and Linda Wood for many valuable suggestions and comments. By advice and by example they have improved this book, though they are in no way responsible for its contents and deficiencies.

Financial support from the Canadian Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council made possible the research on which this book is based. I appreciate this assistance as well as that received from York University, Toronto, which supported this project generously in the form of research funds and a Faculty of Arts Fellowship, which gave me sufficient time to complete the manuscript.

In some parts of this book I have drawn on previously published material. In particular, I would like to acknowledge the permission granted by Yale University Press to use a modified version of my contribution to a volume edited by Jill Morawski, entitled *The Rise of Experimentation in American Psychology*. This appears as chapter 6 of the present volume. Table 5.2 is also taken from this source. Acknowledgment is also due to the American

Psychological Association and the Clinical Psychology Publishing Company for permission to use shorter excerpts from papers previously published in the *American Psychologist* and the *Journal of the History of the Behavioral Sciences*. The last section of chapter 8 is a slightly revised version of part of a chapter that appears in M. G. Ash and W. R. Woodward, eds., *Psychology in Twentieth Century Thought and Society* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).

Last, but by no means least, I want to express my appreciation to Judy Manners for the extraordinary skill and patience she displayed in typing the book manuscript.

Kurt Danziger
Toronto

1

Introduction

What this book is about

What exactly constitutes a field like scientific psychology? Is it constituted by its most innovative and influential contributors; by the scientific findings that it has produced; by the theories it has elaborated; by its concepts, techniques, or professional associations? Obviously, all this and more goes into the making of a field, but most of us would probably see some of these components as playing a more essential role than others. Even if we refuse to commit ourselves explicitly we are likely to imply that certain components define the field more effectively than others by the way we organize our knowledge. For example, in the systematic presentation of information derived from the field of psychology or one of its parts, the material is most commonly organized in terms of prominent contributors, important findings, or influential theories. A perhaps unintended message of such communications is that psychology *is* its theories, *is* its findings, or *is* its individual contributors.

The way in which we organize a field will determine the way we organize its history. If we see the field of psychology as essentially an aggregate of individual contributors, we are likely to treat the history of the subject in terms of a succession of prominent figures. If psychology is its theories or its findings, then its history will become a history of psychological theories or psychological findings. Our organization of the history of the field will also serve as a subtle justification of the way we have characterized the field in the present.

Most psychologists have been taught to characterize their own scientific activity in terms of a framework that is derived from nineteenth-century physical science. They see themselves as individual investigators who seek to accumulate facts about some aspect of nature by the use of appropriate